

Session 40: Jonah as Similar to the Disbelieving Israelites

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is angry because God is merciful to the sinful people of Nineveh. The irony is that Israel exists because God was merciful to sinful people.
- Jonah's hot anger is hyperlinked to Cain's hot anger in [Genesis 4](#).

Jonah Criticizes God's Mercy: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:1-11

Speech of Jonah: 39 Words in Hebrew

A

¹ And it was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him. ² And he prayed to Yahweh and he said, "Please, Yahweh! Was not this my word while I was upon my land? Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish, because **I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger**, and great of covenant love, and **who repents concerning evil**."

Jonah and God Dialogue

B

- a ³ And now, Yahweh, please **take my life from** me,
b for **good is my dying more than my living**.
c ⁴ **And Yahweh said, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you?"**

Jonah's Shelter From the Sun

C

⁵ And Jonah went out from the city, and he sat from the east of the city, and he made for himself there a tent, and he dwelt under it in the shade, until he might see what would happen to the city.

God Provides Shelter

⁶ **And Yahweh Elohim appointed a qiqayon**

D

and it arose from over Jonah,
to be a shade upon his head,
to deliver him from his evil,
and Jonah rejoiced over the qiqayon, a great rejoicing.

God Ruins Shelter

D'

⁷ **And God appointed a worm**
at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it struck the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

No Shelter From the Sun

C'

⁸ And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun struck the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah and God Dialogue

B'

- a And he fainted, and he **requested his life**, to **die** ,
b and he said, "**Good is my dying more than my living** ."
c ⁹ And God said to Jonah, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you over this qiqayon?"
b' And he said, "**It is good that there is heat-anger to me , unto death !**"

Speech of God: 39 Words in Hebrew

A'

¹⁰ And Yahweh said,
"**You had pity** over this **qiqayon** , which you did not labor for it, nor did you make it great, which a
son of the night it was, and a son of the night it perished. ¹¹ And I, **should I not have pity** over
Nineveh, the great city, which there is in it more than twelve ten-thousand humans, who don't know
between their right and their left, and many animals?"

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah's Anger at His Success: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:1-4

Genesis 4 Hyperlinks

A

¹ And it was evil to Jonah, a great **evil** , and **there was heat-anger to him** .

Exodus 14 Hyperlinks

B ² And he prayed to Yahweh and he said, “ **Please, Yahweh (יהוה אנה)** , was not this my word while I was upon my land?

Exodus 34:6 Hyperlink

C Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish, because I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and great of covenant love, and who repents concerning evil.

Exodus 14 Hyperlinks

B' ³ **And now, Yahweh (יהוה ועתה)** take please my life from me, for good is my dying more than my living.

Genesis 4 Hyperlinks

A' ⁴ And Yahweh said, “Is it **good** that **there is heat-anger to you** ?”

Jonah 4:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

This section begins and ends with Jonah’s hot-anger, which was caused by God showing mercy to the Ninevites (A and A’). The shift from narrative statement (A) to God’s question (A’) generates a new plot conflict now that Jonah’s mission to Nineveh has been fulfilled. Jonah’s own stubbornness must be dealt with.

The center sections contain Jonah’s three-part response to Yahweh. It includes an appeal (B), the basis of the appeal (C), and a request (B’).

Hyperlinked Portraits of the Angry Jonah

Jonah and Cain in Genesis 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor’s Translation

And [God’s showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ויחר לו).

Genesis 4:4b-5 NASB*

⁴ And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ויחר לו).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 4:4 Instructor’s Translation

And Yahweh said, “Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (ההיטב לך חרה)?”

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ "Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn't it the case that if you do good (תיטיב), there is exaltation?"

Jonah and the Exodus Generation

From Joseph Ryan Kelly's article, "Jonah, Joel, and the Yhwh Creed" (*Journal of Biblical Literature*, 2013)

Exodus 14:12-13	Jonah 4:2-3, 5
Is this not the word which we spoke to you in Egypt , saying, " Leave us alone, and let us serve the Egyptians!"	And Jonah prayed to Yahweh and said: "Please, Yahweh. Was this not my word while I was still on my own land? "
For it is good (טוב) for us to serve Egypt rather than we die (מותנו מן) in the wilderness .	Therefore I initially fled to Tarshish , for I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and abundant in covenant love, and relenting concerning evil.
And Moses said to the people: "Do not fear, stand by and see the salvation of Yahweh which he will accomplish for you today, for Egypt which you see today, you will not see again, ever. "	And now, Yahweh, please take my life from me, for good (טוב) is my death more than (מן מותי) my life .
And Moses said to the people: "Do not fear, stand by and see the salvation of Yahweh which he will accomplish for you today, for Egypt which you see today, you will not see again, ever. "	And Jonah went outside of the city, and he sat east of the city, and made himself a shelter and sat under its shade, until he could see what might happen in the city .
Comparing Jonah and the Exodus Generation. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

In Exodus 14:11-13, the people have escaped into the wilderness and see Pharaoh's army drawing near. They accuse Moses of leading them out to the desert to die ("What is this thing you've done to us?"). And absurdly, they wish for their death in the wilderness. Moses assures them that despite their complaining, Yahweh will save them and overcome their enemies as they go through the waters of the sea.

In Jonah 4:2-5, Jonah, who was saved through the waters of the sea, has just left the city of Nineveh, and he also absurdly wishes for death. In contrast to Exodus 14, Yahweh is changing and saving his enemies instead of destroying them.

Jonah and Yahweh in Exodus 34:6

Exodus 34:6 NASB*

Then Yahweh passed by in front of him and proclaimed, "Yahweh, Yahweh, compassionate and gracious, long of anger, and great of covenant love and faithfulness ..."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This verse is connected to [Exodus 32:14](#) where God relented of the evil he intended to do to the Israelites.

Jonah 4:2 NASB*

Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish because I knew that you are a God gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and great of covenant love, and who relents concerning evil.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joel 2:12-14 NASB*

¹² “Yet even now,” declares Yahweh,
“Return to me with all your heart,
and with fasting, weeping and mourning;
¹³ and rend your heart and not your garments.”
Now return to Yahweh your God,
for he is gracious and compassionate,
long of anger, abounding in covenant love
and relents concerning evil.
¹⁴ Who knows if he might turn and relent
and leave a blessing behind him.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In [Exodus 32-34](#), Israel was spared from divine judgment because of Moses’ intercession. God’s forgiveness of Israel and his renewal of the covenant is summarized in this dense list of God’s attributes. These are precisely the character traits of God displayed in the story of the golden calf, and they set a pattern of behavior that we will see from God throughout Israel’s history. Notice how both Jonah and Joel have merged the list from Exodus 34:6 with the narrative statement about Yahweh “relenting concerning evil.” God’s relenting is precisely due to Moses’ intercession.

In Jonah 4, the prophet ironically criticizes God for the very attributes that have sustained his existence in the family of Israel. He is angered that God would show the same mercy to his enemies. What’s also ironic is that the Ninevites repented as Israel did in the golden calf story but without any intercessor because Jonah is an anti-Moses!

Reflection Question

What clues does the text give us about Jonah’s anger? How might we be guilty of similar attitudes in our modern-day context?